

Stuck at Silly Point

The search for a suitable cricket coach turned into a battle of wills and a contest of non-issues

■ By Sharda Ugra

Hopefully when the Indians queue up at Heathrow immigration on their tour of England, they will know who their coach is. What we already know is that Indian cricket is adamantly refusing to move up the evolutionary ladder. Going by the noise, this could be 2000, the first time the Indians hired a foreign coach. The conscientious objectors to the idea have remained the same, their arguments have remained the same, and their choice of alternative candidates does not feature any new names. At least none that have made public.

Sri Lanka and Pakistan, with equally capricious Boards, now know how to hunt for coaches. They put out ads, invite candidates. India's method involves big-name committees, shooting in the dark, Chinese whispers and conspiracy theories.

What do the Indians look for when picking a coach? Er, who cares because coaches, apparently, come in only two kinds: Indian and foreign. Other qualities like a track record, the ability to manage men, to work hard, to build trust, are, apparently, built into passports, rather than the men carrying them.

Dav Whatmore, as is known, is the front-runner but could be part of a package deal which includes G.R. Viswanath as batting consultant. South African Graham Ford is a late entrant with backers in the team, but more names will be thrown into the meeting for dramatic effect.

In 1990, former India batsman Nari Contractor went to England to find a coach for the Mumbai Cricket

Association's bowling scheme. When no one impressed him, he returned and was not satisfied until he ran into former England fast bowler Frank Tyson. Twenty-seven bowlers from that scheme played first-class cricket and one of them, Paras Mhambrey, is a coach himself today. That's the effect the right man can have in a job.

Like Mhambrey, there are other former players who have committed **PACKAGE DEAL: Whatmore (left) may team up with Viswanath**

it about him that has so incensed two of our luminaries, Kapil Dev and Sunil Gavaskar. When asked about Whatmore taking the job he once did (without any great distinction) Kapil Dev responded, "Who is Whatmore? Why do we need to talk about Whatmore?" So often has Kapil *paaji* replied to questions by asking "Who is...?" in his fabricated earthiness, that he should consider patenting the response to prevent other rent-a-quote artists from making capital out of it.

Sunil Gavaskar's recent newspaper columns have contained a series of sniper attacks on Whatmore. May 23: "While it is no secret that (Habibul) Bashar is not the greatest tactical captain, what was the dressing room doing?" May 26: "Bangladesh's limited success... is largely a matter of a good team playing them having a bad day... If eyes aren't opened after this, then we are a myopic nation." May 28: "What more does it take to prove that they have been plain lucky in their odd one-day wins and have made zilch progress in Test cricket? Nothing more, I guess." You get the drift.

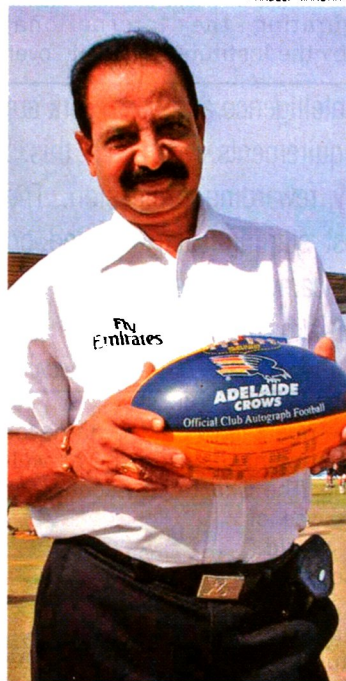
For a columnist, all this is fair game but Gavaskar was also part of

the panel to pick the new coach. Couldn't a candidate believe Gavaskar has it in for him? Didn't this strident public stance muddy the process? Besides, is any of it constructive?

As India staggered into a new season, the search to find a perfect fit for their backroom turned into a battle of wills, a contest of non-issues and an exercise in self-aggrandisement. ■

AP PHOTO: MATT DUNHAM

PRADEEP MANDHAN



While other countries pick coaches in a planned manner, the BCCI believes in shooting in the dark

themselves to cricket coaching like students, rather than gurus. Robin Singh and Venkatesh Prasad are already with the team. It won't be long before an Indian heads our support staff. But to push for an Indian for the sake of his Indianness is meaningless.

This is no defence of or campaign for Whatmore. But the Sri Lanka-born Australian must be wondering what is